

Hebrews 13:9

Be not carried about with divers and strange doctrines. For it is a good thing that the heart be established with grace^{G5485}; not with meats, which have not profited them that have been occupied therein.

- Hebrews chapter 13 is the last chapter of the book of Hebrews. It concludes itself with many concise summaries of commands and exhortations.
- Its very profitable to take the time to think each sentence through very carefully, comparing scripture to scripture as needed and/or consulting the resources we know to be profitable to understand what each word means.

Hebrews 13:9a

Be not carried about with divers and strange doctrines.

- Be not
 - This is a thing we are commanded to avoid.
- carried
 - To be carried is to have someone bear you but that usage doesn't make sense here because teachings (doctrines) don't carry things. Carry can also mean "to effect, to urge, impel, lead or draw, to imply or import, to contain or comprise, to support or sustain, to remove, lead or drive"
 - Would you let someone or something carry you that you don't trust? Therefore, trust is implied.
- about
 - Somewhere other than where you are.
 - From one place to another.
- with divers
 - Diversity is many different things, a wide variety.
- and strange
 - The opposite of strange is familiar. Strange can also mean odd, unusual, or irregular.
 - If scripture is what we're to be familiar with, then lies are an example of something that is strange.
- doctrines
 - Doctrines are teachings, knowledge, and the truths of the gospel in general.

Putting it all together we can begin to understand:

- Many different strange teachings exist in the world.
 - If they didn't exist it doesn't make much sense that we would be commanded to avoid them.
- Do not put your trust in those false teachings (lies), instead trust in what God has taught you (the truth)([Heb. 6:18b](#)).
 - Willingly or unwillingly letting yourself be deceived means that on some level you *believe* what was told you and a consequence of that is that it affects/changes your thoughts and/or behavior.

If we are commanded to avoid false teachings (like a boat on the sea with no rudder or sail is tossed about) what do you think the advice is? The opposite of avoiding false teachings (stay away from them) is to keep ourselves close to the truth. Our “boat” needs a “rudder” to steer it and a “sail” to push it along safely and they are God’s word and the Holy Ghost.

In [John 17:17](#) Jesus tells us that God’s word is truth so studying and memorizing God’s word can help steer our boat in any situation. In [John 16:13](#) Jesus tells us that the Spirit of truth (the Holy Ghost which indwells every reborn Christian) will guide us into all truth. Since it’s possible to resist the Holy Ghost ([Luke 13:34](#), [1 Thess. 5:19](#), [Acts 7:51](#), [Eph. 4:30](#)) and Jesus said that “he will guide you into all truth” it becomes crucial that we are willing to receive that guidance and let Him push our boat along. Several good Christian habits arise from this that result in our “boat” being both stable and moving along safely avoiding obstacles:

- Prayer
- Submitting to God’s will
- Studying God’s word

Now that we know what to do how do we do it? We take what we’ve learned from scripture and we put it into practice.

Imagine a scenario where someone tells you something and concludes with “it’s in the bible” but they don’t show you where it is. Or, you see something on TV and they make a statement regarding doctrine (teachings) from the Bible. Assume they are implying that what they just told you is the truth. Do you blindly accept it without question? What do you do when someone gives you any other advice? Do you check it against what you know? Do you consult anyone else for advice? Who is the expert on scripture? If His spirit is inside of us, do we need to go far for everything we need?

What did Jesus do in [Matthew 4:5-7](#) when the devil quoted two scripture verses ([Psalm 91:11,12](#)) and told Him to jump off the pinnacle of the temple? Did Jesus assume because the devil used scripture that it was ok to jump? Read it carefully and consider for yourself. What Jesus did in that moment between the devil’s statement and His response is something all Christians should endeavor to do.

If the devil tests you with scripture it will likely ([Genesis 3:1](#)) sound a like a good idea (as he did with Jesus). Since the Holy Ghost indwells every reborn Christian we can and should develop a habit of asking Him (prayer). At other times, “simple” false teachings can be quickly discarded by the fact that they obviously contradict scripture.

The key to understanding whether a teaching (doctrine) is truth or not is simple but it’s a habit that must be nurtured. It involves both prayer and scripture. A combination of prayer and study is required to avoid common mistakes such as leaning on your own understanding ([Proverbs 3:5](#)) or using the wisdom of the world ([1 Cor. 2:6,7](#), [1 Cor. 3:19a](#)).

The truth to all the questions that a Christian might have are found while and by developing a regular habit of both prayer and study of scripture. Not only did Jesus tell us that His Spirit would guide us into all truth but often we are invited to partake of that wisdom ([Proverbs 3:15](#), [Proverbs 9:1-6](#), [Psalm 119:105](#), [James 1:5](#)).

Hebrews 13:9b-9d

For it is a good thing that the heart be established^{G950} with grace^{G5485}; not with meats, which have not profited them that have been occupied therein.

- Understanding the first part of **Hebrews 13:9** is, as you might guess, very helpful in understanding the second part and the next verse also adds to our understanding.
- To have your heart established (to stabilize, to make stable, to make firm, confirm, make sure) is to be well grounded (planted firmly) in the truth (G950, **Colossians 1:23**).
- Generally, grace is the unmerited favor of God and that includes all His gifts through Jesus Christ and in this case the guidance He gives us via the Spirit of truth which we learned from **9a**.
- “Meats” is plural for food (here, collectively referring to the bread and flesh used to sacrifice at the temple).
- We also learn that those sacrifices are not profitable.
- And so verse **9b-9d** is contrasting the grace given by God to sacrifices. The former is good and the latter is not profitable (vain, empty, good for nothing, not good).

Hebrews 13:10

We have an altar, whereof they have no right to eat which serve the tabernacle.

- Those who serve the tabernacle are the Levite priests.
- The contrast here is between the “old covenant” or the “old way” (sacrificing at the temple for sin, the law of Moses) and the “new covenant” or the new and living way (**Heb. 10:20, Matt. 26:28, Heb. 8:13**) which is through Jesus Christ.
- Since they have no right to eat at our altar (a place of sacrifice), an obvious interpretation becomes the contrast between those who are saved and those who are not. Those without Jesus and those who approach God not through Jesus are separated from God and He will not hear them (**Isaiah 59:2**).
- This verse adds to our understanding of **9c** by telling us which definition of “meats” we should use.
 - Besides food, meat can also refer to scripture itself (**Hebrews 5:12,14**), also known as the oracles of God.

All this considered, **Hebrews 13:9** is a command to pray, submit to God’s will, and study scripture because those are the requirements to fulfill the command: “Be not carried about with divers and strange doctrines.”

What?	Be not carried about with divers and strange doctrines.		
How?	Pray	Submit to God’s will	Study scripture

Practice topics

Some popular false doctrines are:

- The more money you “give to God”, the more money He will give to you.
- You must behave a certain way to receive the gift of salvation.
- Handling deadly animals is a way to prove your faith.
- Christians are forbidden from eating certain kinds of foods.
- Praying to or worshiping Mary is appropriate.
- Confessing your sins to a priest and doing what he tells you can free you from the penalties.
- Forbidding to marry is biblical.
- Sexual relations outside of marriage are not sin as long as they aren't immoral.

Reborn Christians understandably have many different questions such as:

- Should a male Christian be circumcised?
- Should a Christian abstain from consuming blood?
- What are commands that apply to all Christians?
- Should a Christian honor the Sabbath and keep it holy?
- Is it ok for a Christian to marry a person who is not saved?
- How should a Christian dress, speak, conduct business, etc.?
- What ministry has God called me to?
- Why is it normal to expect to suffer persecution as a Christian?
- How do I know for sure that I am saved?
- What should a Christian do when they sin?
- If a law says something is ok does that mean it's ok to do it?

Cross references (courtesy of tsk-online.com)

Hebrews 13:9a (carried)	Matthew 24:4, Matthew 24:24, Acts 20:30, Romans 16:17,18, 2 Corinthians 11:11-15, Galatians 1:6-9, Ephesians 4:14, Ephesians 5:6, Colossians 2:4, Colossians 2:8, 2 Thessalonians 2:2, 1 Timothy 4:1-3, 1 Timothy 6:3-5, 1 Timothy 6:20, 1 John 4:1, Jude 1:3
Hebrews 13:9b (it is)	Acts 20:32, 2 Corinthians 1:21, Galatians 6:1, 2 Thessalonians 2:17, 2 Timothy 2:1,2
Hebrews 13:9c (not with)	Hebrews 9:9,10, Leviticus 11:1-47, Deuteronomy 14:3-21, Acts 10:14-16, Romans 14:2, Romans 14:6, Romans 14:17, 1 Corinthians 6:13, 1 Corinthians 8:8, Colossians 2:16-20, 1 Timothy 4:3-5, Titus 1:14,15

Strong's #s referenced

G5485	χάρις cháris, khar'-ece; from G5463; graciousness (as gratifying), of manner or act (abstract or concrete; literal, figurative or spiritual; especially the divine influence upon the heart, and its reflection in the life; including gratitude):—acceptable, benefit, favour, gift, grace(-ious), joy, liberality, pleasure, thank(-s, -worthy).
G950	βεβαιόω bebaióō, beb-ah-yo'-o; from G949; to stabilize (figuratively):—confirm, (e-)stablish.